



mobile watch

China Mobile's subscriber base passed the 450 million mark this year. The number is more than the combined populations of several small countries.

CONNECTIONS



When cell phone's become Voting machines

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No we're not talking about voting for your favourite star in Indian Idol. But there is the distinct possibility of mobile devices being used as voting machines for the next elections. Perhaps this article and the concept is a bit ahead of its time but indicators towards this electronic shift have already found their way into popular culture. Do the "what an idea sir ji" ads we're being bombarded with so often, strike a chord? Or even the numerous reality shows where the contestants' fate is decided by the mobile voting public. Another instance that comes to mind occurred two years ago, when the Taj Mahal's right to be amongst the seven wonders of the world was put to a vote. Back then about 165 million mobile phones doubled up as voting machines and surprised the international community.

Think about it – the juggernaut of India's mobile subscriber base shows no sign of stopping. Despite the downturn it stands at around 360 million (36 crore), with close to ten million connections being added every month. This figure, however impressive, may not be close to the eligible voting population of today, but by the time the next election takes place in 2014, the numbers may be closing. A report by

Gartner last year expected the subscriber base to hit 73.7 crore connections by 2012, owing to a compound annual growth rate of 21 per cent in the same period. Soon the Kafkaesque scenario of people being recognised by numbers and not names might become a reality. Except the numbers won't be government appointed dog tags but our very own cell phone numbers. One might argue that even a large subscriber base if it doesn't cover half the country's numerical strength, doesn't represent a valid cross section of the population. True. But if the infrastructure allows it, those that can exercise the option should be allowed to.

In other parts of the world this possibility is being seriously considered. VeriSign, the Internet infrastructure services provider, made a prediction just recently that voting by mobile devices could become a reality in the US by 2012. It also predicts that citizens will have a greater connect with their elected representatives through the mobile medium. A small reflection of this is happening in India but only it's the other way around with politicians using SMSs to reach citizens in their constituency.

In conclusion, if the problem of authentication and accountability can be overcome by developing the appropriate infrastructure, the TRAI and EC should seriously consider the possibility.

Phone a Friend



Turn Left
at the next
signal

You are completely lost and on your way to an important even in an unfamiliar part of town. Worse yet, you are in a new city altogether and don't know what to do. We've all faced this situation and wished for a GPS device. GPS however is

not within everyone's reach and doesn't make sense for occasional use. But what if you could get turn-by-turn directions as a service then? Now you can! SatNav has launched India's first voice-based Navigation Direction Service – SatGuide LCU (It stands for "Lost? Call Us!") available to all phone users across India. With the launch of this service, finding your destination is theoretically just a phone call away.

When you call in, an actual person will ask you for your details and will guide you to your destination. The other option

is an SMS with distances and road names along with landmarks. The service works on a prepaid voucher model. Users get toll free calling accessibility from any telecom provider to be connected to a trained agent. To access the service, the customer will just have to purchase vouchers worth Rs. 100 from the SatGuide website, www.satguide.in, to register with the service. These contain 15 minutes of talk time. In addition, the vouchers will be made available through retail partners such as E-Zone, Croma, Staples and Reliance AutoZone, all over the country in a phased manner. Higher value vouchers are also available.

The service is available in Hindi and English between 6.30 to 11.30 pm. The maps have been developed in house by the company with detailed street level road maps of 200+ cities and include more than 15 lakh destinations.

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